MOOD OF THE NATION

WORK-LIFE BALANCE

BLOCK THE BURNOUT

As stress impacts more than half the workforce and every fourth employee fails to strike work-life balance, more and more back shorter work weeks

By SONAL KHETARPAL



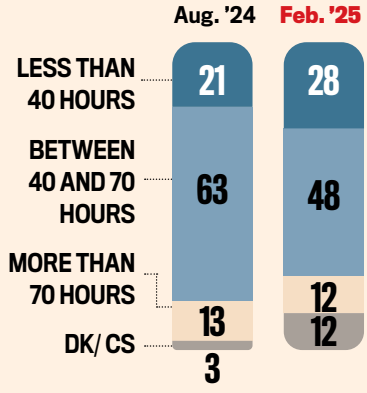
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Work-life balance has been a topic of intense debate in India for the past year. More recently, Larsen & Toubro (L&T) chairman S.N. Subrahmanyan endorsed a 90-hour work week, suggesting employees should also pitch in on Sundays. This came months after the tragic death of 26-year-old Anna Sebastian Perayil, an employee at Ernst & Young's member firm office in Pune, brought workplace stress into sharp focus. Earlier, Infosys founder N.R. Narayana Murthy's proposal for 70-hour work weeks had already stirred controversy.

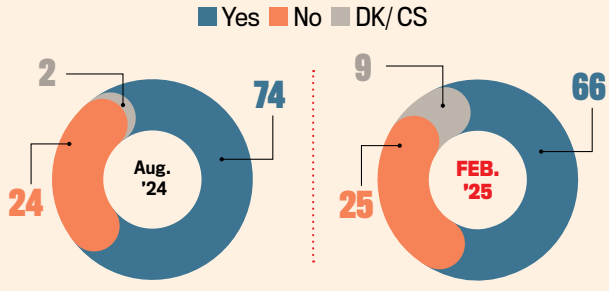
The India Today Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll highlights a divided workforce. While 48.1 per cent of the respondents are fine with working 40-70 hours per week (i.e. 8-14 hours daily, in case of five-day work weeks), there's a clear shift in attitudes. Their percentage has dropped from 62.7 per cent in August 2024, suggesting growing awareness of burnout. At the same time, preference for less than 40-hour work weeks has gone up by seven percentage points—from 20.9 per cent to 27.8 per cent. A smaller but significant 12.2 per cent still support Murthy's 70-hour work-week proposal, highlighting a group that believes extreme dedication is key to success.

The survey also shows a decline in employee satisfaction with work-life balance in their current job. Over the past six months, it has fallen from 74.3 per cent to 65.7 per cent. One out of every four respondents struggles to maintain balance, pointing to challenges in certain roles, industries or workplace policies. Stress levels further emphasise the issue: 23.6 per cent feel stressed frequently, while 30 per cent experience it occasionally, meaning for over half the workforce, stress is a common experience. On a positive note, 40 per cent report rare to no stress, suggesting manageable workloads or effective coping strategies. However, with declining enthusiasm for long hours, it's imperative that companies start focusing on productivity rather than simply counting hours. ■

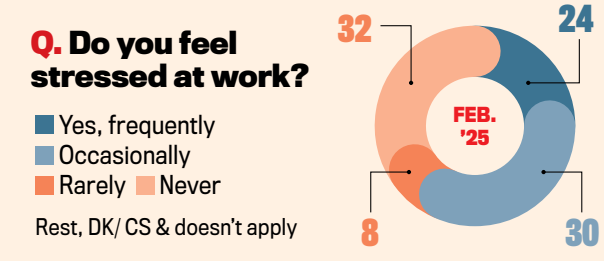
Q. What should be the ideal weekly work hours to maintain required productivity at work and lead a happy personal life?



Q. Is it possible to maintain work-life balance in your current job?



Q. Do you feel stressed at work?



DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say; all figures in % and rounded off